RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Faith & Heresy: The Rambam's Conclusion

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 19

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: the concluding paragraph on the Thirteen Principles, with Hilchot Issurei Bi'ah, Hilchot Teshuvah, Hilchot Mamrim, the Shulchan Aruch, the Chazon Ish and Rav Kook

Shiur: Part 19 (the final shiur) of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 10 March 2026 (after Purim)

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Where We Are

We began **after Sukkot**: the Rambam on **Olam HaBa** and the afterlife, then, "since this Mishnah discusses Olam HaBa," **the principles needed for a portion in it**.

	Principles
Hashem	**1** exists, **2** one, **3** no body, **4** first, before all, **5** serve nothing else
Revelation	**6** prophecy, **7** Moshe the greatest prophet, **8** Torah from heaven, **9** it won't change
Consequences	**10** Hashem knows our deeds and thoughts, **11** reward and punishment, **12** Mashiach, **13** ***Techiyat HaMetim*** (simply understood: **physical**)

Tonight: the Rambam's final paragraph. "**An incredible statement.**"

Part 1: The Text

וכאשר יאמין האדם אלה היסודות כולם, ונתבררה אמונתו בהם, הוא נכנס בכלל ישראל, ומצוה לאהבו ולרחם עליו ולנהוג עמו בכל מה שצוה השם יתברך איש לאחיו מן האהבה והאחוה. ואפילו עשה מה שיכול מן העבירות מחמת התאוה ותגבורת הטבע הגרוע, הוא נענש כפי חטאיו, ויש לו חלק לעולם הבא, והוא מפושעי ישראל.

A believer in all thirteen	
Status	**Within *Klal Yisrael***, once his faith is **clear** to him, "**not just *we learnt it***"
Our duty	**Love him, have compassion** (help him, **charity when he needs it**), and **every interpersonal mitzvah** of brotherhood
Even if	He commits **every sin he can, from desire** and the overpowering of his lower nature: "**eats non-kosher, even eats on Yom Kippur**; he wants to eat and finds it hard"
Then	**Punished for his sins**, but **he has a portion in Olam HaBa**: **one of the sinners of Israel**

"**Hate the sin, love the sinner.** He'll have to **reconcile what he's done**, but if he's **going through a hard time**, **we have a mitzvah from the Torah to help him**."

וכשיפקפק אדם ביסוד מאלו היסודות, הרי יצא מן הכלל, וכפר בעיקר, ונקרא מין ואפיקורוס, וקוצץ בנטיעות, ומצוה לשנאתו ולאבדו, ועליו נאמר: הלא משנאיך ה׳ אשנא.

One who rejects any one principle	
Status	**Has left the community**; **denied a fundamental**; called ***min*** and ***apikoros***; **"cuts the plantings"**
Our duty	**"A mitzvah to hate him and destroy him."** "**That's what the Rambam says. I'm not going to dilute his words.**"
Verse	**an enemy of Hashem** is one who denies a principle: **הלא משנאיך ה׳ אשנא**

The closing lines

והארכתי בדברים הרבה ויצאתי מענין חבורי, אבל עשיתי זאת לפי שראיתי בו תועלת באמונה, לפי שאספתי בו דברים מועילים מפוזרים מספרים גדולים. ולכן דע אותם והצלח בהם, וחזור עליהם פעמים רבות, והתבונן בהם התבוננות יפה. ואם ישיאך לבך ותחשוב שהבנת ענינם מפעם אחת או מעשרה, ה׳ יודע שהשיאך על שקר. ולכן אל תמהר בקריאתו, כי אני לא חברתיו כפי מה שנזדמן לי, אלא אחר עיון גדול והתבוננות, ואחר שראיתי דעות ברורות ואמיתיות... וידעתי מה שראוי להאמין ממנו, והבאתי ראיה בטענות ובראיות על כל ענין וענין. ה׳ יתברך ינחני בדרך הטובה. ואחזור לפרק.

- "**I went on at length, beyond my purpose**, because it **benefits faith**: I gathered **useful things scattered across great books**."
- "**Know them, go over them many times, reflect deeply.** If your heart tells you **you've understood after once, or ten times, Hashem knows it's deceived you. Don't rush.**" "**That's why we went through each principle properly, in detail.**"
- "**I wrote this only after great study and reflection**, weighing true views against false, **with proof for each**."
- "**May Hashem guide me on the good path. And I return to the chapter**": back to the Mishnah.

Part 2: Not Knowing vs Rejecting

The convert (Hilchot Issurei Bi'ah 14:2)

When a prospective convert accepts that it's hard and still wants it: **מודיעין אותו עיקרי הדת, שהוא ייחוד השם ואיסור עבודה זרה, ומאריכין בדבר זה**, plus **some mitzvot**. **That's it.**

"**He needn't know about Mashiach or resurrection**, only **Principles 1, 2 and 5**, at length. **Presumably he'll learn the rest once he's Jewish. But didn't the Rambam just say that without the thirteen you're not part of *Klal Yisrael*?**"

The answer: the Rambam's word is **שיפקפק / ונתקלקל**: **active rejection**.

	Status
"I don't know there's a Mashiach, a resurrection, reward and punishment; I wasn't taught"	**Part of Am Yisrael.** "Of course you **should** know it, but **you haven't rejected it**."
Taught, and rejects it: *there's no Mashiach, no resurrection*	***Kofer***
The exception: Principle 3	**Ignorance *is* rejection.** "Even if you were **taught God has a body and sits on a throne in heaven**, you're a heretic," and **the Rambam is sharp on this in the Moreh**. **It's the opposite of the truth.**

Point one: we're talking about *active* rejection.

Heresy vs *karet* sins

Hilchot Teshuvah 3 lists **24** with no portion in Olam HaBa: **about half** are the principles; the rest are other sins, e.g. ***machti'ei harabim***, **causing the public to sin** (**Yerovam ben Nevat** set up idols publicly; or deliberately **teaching people the wrong thing**).

	Karet sinner (e.g. *machti harabim*)	***Apikoros***
Olam HaBa (without teshuvah)	**None**	**None**
Am Yisrael	**Still part of it**	**Not part of it**
Our duty	**Still love him**	**Distance**: "a mitzvah to hate and destroy"
Minyan	Counts	**Doesn't count**: "I'm not talking about someone who just doesn't know what Mashiach is, but one who says in shul *I don't believe the Torah is from heaven*"
Shechitah	Kosher	**Treif**, even if he **knows all the laws and does it precisely**

"**That is the gravity of this paragraph.**"

"**Unfortunately we know people who don't accept all thirteen. How do we relate to them?** Do we take the Rambam's words, **distance, hate, push away**? **Or is there another understanding, one the Rambam would agree with?**" **Six points.**

Part 3: Six Considerations

1. Who is an *apikoros*?

That an *apikoros* has no portion in Olam HaBa is a Mishnah. Accepted. But **the Gemara (Sanhedrin 99b)** defines him differently:

Opinion	*Apikoros* =
One	**מבזה תלמיד חכם: disparages a Torah scholar**
Other	**מבזה חברו בפני תלמיד חכם: disparages his fellow before a scholar**

The Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 3:8) instead defines him as **one who denies prophecy, or Moshe's**. **The Beit Yosef**, **Kesef Mishneh** and **Vilna Gaon** ask: **ומכל מקום קשה לי, דאמרינן מאן אפיקורוס... צריך טעם למה השמיטה רבנו וכתב במקומה מה שכתב.**

The Me'iri (a difficult answer): **disparage the Sages and you'll come to deny everything**: **they're the guardians of the Torah, of prophecy, of revelation**.

"**My point: already in the Gemara there's a discussion of *what an apikoros is." And not everyone counts thirteen: Albo's Ikkarim*** has **three**; **Crescas** (*Or Hashem*) and **the Radbaz** disagree too.

Principle 3 again: the Ra'avad: והלא גדולים וטובים ממנו: **greater and better men** (some **Ba'alei Tosafot**) **believed in God's corporeality**. "**Are they all *kofrim*? Maybe the Rambam would say so.** But **you first have to define an *apikoros*, and it's not always clear.**"

But some principles everyone accepts: **belief in God**, **one God, not two**. **On that, the Gemara says to kill him. So what then?**

2. The Chazon Ish: "only when Providence was revealed"

Shulchan Aruch, Yoreh De'ah 158:2: האפיקורסים, והם הכופרים בתורה ובנבואה מישראל, מצוה להרגן; אם יש בידו להרגן בסייף בפרהסיא, הורגן; ואם לאו, היה מסבב בסיבות עד שיסבב הריגתו. כיצד? ראה אחד מהם שנפל לבאר והסולם בבאר, קודם ומסלקו ואומר: הריני טרוד להוריד בני מן הגג ואחזירנו לך.

If you can, **openly**; if not (**the law of the land**), **indirectly**: he's fallen in a well with a ladder there; **take the ladder**: *"I'm busy getting my son down from the roof, I'll bring it back."* "**Unbelievable. From the Gemara**, **in the Rambam**, and **the Shulchan Aruch, only 500 years ago**."

The Chazon Ish (R. Avraham Yeshayahu Karelitz; late 1800s to mid-1950s; begun ~1911, written before the Holocaust), **Yoreh De'ah 2:16**:

ונראה דאין דין מורידין אלא בזמן שהשגחתו יתברך גלויה, כמו בזמן שהיו נסים מצויים ומשמש בת קול, וצדיקי הדור תחת השגחה פרטית הנראית לכל עין... ואז היה ביעור רשעים גדרו של עולם, שהכל ידעו כי הדחת הדור מביא פורענות לעולם... אבל בזמן ההעלם, שנכרתה האמונה מדלת העם, אין במעשה הורדה גדר הפרצה אלא הוספה בפרצה, שיהיה בעיניהם כמעשה השחתה ואלמות ח״ו. וכיון שכל עצמנו לתקן, אין הדין נוהג בשעה שאין בו תיקון. ועלינו להחזירם בעבותות אהבה ולהעמידם בקרן אורה במה שידינו מגעת.

When Providence is **revealed** (miracles, *bat kol*, visible *hashgachah pratit*)	In a time of **concealment**
Removing the wicked fixes the world: everyone sees **leading the generation astray brings calamity**	Even **simple people** struggle with faith; **acting would widen the breach**: people would see it as **destruction and violence**: "**look how religious people behave**"
The law applies	**The law exists to repair, so where it doesn't repair, it doesn't apply**

"We must bring them back with cords of love, and raise them up in a ray of light, as far as we can."

The Rabbi's comments:

1. "**The Chazon Ish isn't some liberal rabbi**: revered in the Charedi world, **the *posek hador* for Ashkenazim** of the last generation. **And he wrote it *before* the Holocaust: *al achat kamah vekamah* after it.**"

2. "**Very creative.** Was there **revealed providence** in **the 1500s**, when the Shulchan Aruch codified it? **The 1100s**, for the Rambam? **Nothing drastically changed between the 1500s and the 1900s.** The Rambam records non-practical laws, but **the Shulchan Aruch only records practical halachah**, nothing from Temple times. **And yet the Chazon Ish says it no longer applies. What's changed? I'll leave you to work that out.**"

3. "**He could have stopped at *it doesn't apply*. He doesn't: *we must bring them back with cords of love*.**"

A parallel: suicide. The Gemara: **no mourning**, **not buried in a Jewish cemetery**: "quite severe." **Today everyone who takes their own life is buried in *kever Yisrael*.** "**I've had the very unfortunate experience of a *levayah* for a teenager who took his own life.**" The *poskim* of the last 50–100 years: **such a person is essentially mentally ill**. "**Lovely, and 100% great that our *poskim* say this, but it begs the question: when does the original halachah apply? Maybe things have changed.**"

3. *Tinok shenishba* (Hilchot Mamrim 3:3)

במה דברים אמורים? באיש שכפר בתורה שבעל פה במחשבתו ובדברים שנראו לו, והלך אחר דעתו הקלה ואחר שרירות לבו, וכופר בתורה שבעל פה תחילה, כצדוק ובייתוס וכל התועים אחריהם. אבל בני התועים האלה ובני בניהם, שהדיחו אותם אבותם ונולדו במינות וגדלו אותן עליו, הרי הן כתינוק שנשבה לבין הגויים וגדלוהו הגויים על דתם, שהוא אנוס... ואף על פי ששמע אחר כך שהיה יהודי וראה היהודים ודתם, הרי הוא כאנוס, שהרי גדלוהו על טעותם. כך אלו שאמרנו, האוחזים בדרכי אבותם הקראים שטעו. לפיכך ראוי להחזירן בתשובה ולמשוך אותם בדברי שלום עד שיחזרו לאיתן התורה.

***Ones*, duress:** under duress even **adultery or murder**, though wrong, **isn't punished by death**. "**We learnt this in the Rambam's letters.**"

The Rambam extends *ones* dramatically: born and raised among heretics (his case: **the Karaites**) = **compelled**, **like a child captured and raised by gentiles** (*tinok shenishba*, a concept in the Gemara; **Jewish children taken by Christians** and raised Christian).

"**For his time, quite groundbreaking.** So **everyone raised in non-religious homes, Reform or Conservative homes**, and **I'd go further: even the rabbis of those movements, if that's how they were raised**: the Rambam would perhaps say **they're *tinok shenishba***. **Not only no mitzvah to hate them: a mitzvah to love them and bring them back.**"

4. Intellectual *ones* (the Rabbi's own suggestion)

"**My own idea. I don't know how true it is, I have no proof, but I believe it.**" The Rambam limits it to one who **went after דעתו הקלה ושרירות לבו**: **his shallow opinion and the caprice of his heart**. **So perhaps there's an *intellectual ones***: someone who **thought it through seriously** and was **intellectually compelled** isn't that person.

5. Emotional *ones*: Rav Kook (*Iggerot HaRe'iyah* I, letter 138, 5678/1918)

Background (the testimony laws): a public Shabbat desecrator can't testify. Yet **one suspected of *arayot*** (adultery) **can**, **because יצרו תקפו: his inclination overpowered him**. "**It's terrible, but deep down he's a good person**, so we don't suspect him of **lying in court**."

A father wrote to Rav Kook: his son had left religion.

- "**I understand why you're sad.** But if you think, as many do, that **the right thing is to abandon those who left Torah and faith through the storm of the times** (**על ידי זרם הזמן הסוער**), **הנני אומר בפה מלא שלא זו הדרך שה' חפץ בה**: **I say outright: that is not the way Hashem wants.**"

- **As one suspected of *arayot* is *anus* because his inclination overpowered him, so the current of the age is like a wicked maidservant**, given **great power**, **enticing our young people with all her charms** to follow her. **הם אנוסים גמורים, וחלילה לנו לדון אונס כרצון**: **they are under complete duress; God forbid we judge duress as free will.**

- **The inner Jewish soul is still in their hearts**; **don't compare them to the wicked**. **When times change they'll return.**

- **His advice: bring him near**, **explain** as you can, and above all **let him keep a love for the nation**, Jewish at least culturally.

"**Radical too.** Our youth, **the jaded**, are **enticed by the hedonistic culture we live in**. **Emotional *ones***: bring them back **through love**, and **intellectual discourse**."

6. No proper rebuke

Some Rishonim: one who **hasn't been rebuked**, told **clearly and unequivocally**, is still **an *anus***.

Arachin 16b: Rabbi Tarfon: תמהני אם יש בדור הזה מי שמקבל תוכחה: *I'd be surprised if anyone in this generation can accept rebuke*. **Rabbi Elazar ben Azariah: תמהני אם יש בדור הזה שיודע להוכיח**: *I'd be surprised if anyone knows how to give it*.

"**If you're only liable once properly rebuked, and almost no one knows how to rebuke... something to think about.**"

Conclusion

#	Consideration
1	**Not everyone accepts the Rambam's definition** of *apikoros* (the Gemara; Albo, Crescas, Radbaz; the Ra'avad on corporeality)
2	**The Chazon Ish:** the law applied **only when Providence was revealed**; today, **cords of love**
3	**The Rambam's own *tinok shenishba***: raised in a home with the wrong beliefs
4	**Intellectual *ones***
5	**Rav Kook's emotional *ones*: the storm of the age**
6	**No one properly rebuked**, and **no one who knows how to rebuke**

"**Yes, we must accept the Rambam's principles, teach them and go over them, as he told us: not once, not ten times, all the time.** And **one who rejects them, we must distance. But I'd say even the Rambam, today, on the basis of one of these six, would say: even clear and absolute *kofrim*, we still have a duty to try to bring them back, to love them, to help them, to be there for them, and to teach them the real, authentic Torah.**"

Summary

1. **Believe all thirteen** and you're **within *Klal Yisrael***, owed **love and help**, **even if you sin greatly** from desire: **a sinner of Israel, with a portion in Olam HaBa**.
2. **Reject one** and you've **left the community**: ***min*, *apikoros***, *"a mitzvah to hate and destroy,' no minyan, treif shechitah: graver than* karet *sins**.
3. **"Go over them many times; don't think once or ten times is enough."**
4. **Only *active* rejection counts**: **converts** learn only **one God and no idolatry**; except **corporeality**, where **ignorance itself is heresy**.
5. **Six reasons for love today: definition**, **the Chazon Ish**, ***tinok shenishba***, **intellectual *ones***, **Rav Kook's emotional *ones***, **no proper rebuke**.

Coming Up

The end of the series. "Baruch Hashem, this past year we've learnt the Rambam's Introduction to the Mishnah, his Introduction to Perek Chelek, and his Introduction to Mishneh Torah." No shiur next Tuesday; in two weeks, the week before Pesach, we begin the *Moreh Nevuchim, the Guide for the Perplexed*.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/w0lmqAt7qjE · More shiurim: rabbikada.com